

Trigeminal Nerve Dysfunction ("Dropped Jaw")

Key point: most dogs with a dropped jaw on **both sides** have idiopathic trigeminal neuritis and **recover within 2–3 weeks** with supportive care.

What is it?

The **trigeminal nerve** (cranial nerve V) controls the chewing muscles and provides feeling to the face. When it does not work, the dog cannot close its mouth and has trouble eating.

Causes

- **Idiopathic trigeminal neuritis (ITN)** — about 53% of cases. Inflammation of unknown cause, usually **both sides**, usually resolves on its own.
- **Inflammatory neuritis** — about 16%; immune-related, one or both sides.
- **Tumors** — about 31%; affect **one side only**, more common in older dogs.

Both sides affected → about a 96% chance it is ITN.

One side affected → imaging is needed to look for a tumor.

Signs

- **Dropped jaw** — cannot close the mouth
- Food and water falling from the mouth; drooling
- Over time, **muscle wasting** of the temples and cheeks
- Less often: loss of facial feeling, Horner's syndrome (small pupil, droopy eyelid)

Most dogs with ITN have **normal facial feeling** and remain bright and comfortable.

Diagnosis

- Neurological exam; ruling out jaw injury, rabies exposure and masticatory muscle myositis
- **MRI** — best test for tumors or nerve inflammation, especially if one-sided or atypical

- Blood tests (including thyroid); sometimes spinal fluid analysis

Treatment

- **ITN:** self-limiting. Steroids are sometimes used early, but there is little evidence they speed recovery.
- **Inflammatory neuritis:** may respond to immunosuppressive medication.
- **Tumors:** stereotactic radiation therapy or surgery in select cases.

Care at home — the most important part

- **Hand-feed meatballs** of soft canned food, placed at the back of the tongue; your dog can still swallow
- **Raise food and water bowls;** offer gruel/slurry of canned food and water
- **Water by syringe** (no needle) in the corner of the mouth — squirt slowly and let your dog swallow
- Keep your dog **hydrated** — check gum moisture
- Wipe the mouth and face after meals to prevent skin irritation
- **Weigh weekly** — major weight loss may mean a temporary feeding tube is needed

Expected recovery (ITN)

- Weeks 1–2: still cannot close the jaw; intensive hand-feeding
- Weeks 2–3: gradual improvement
- Weeks 3–4: most dogs are eating normally. Recurrence is possible but uncommon.

Call us if

Your dog is not drinking or seems dehydrated, loses more than 10% of body weight, has breathing trouble, is not improving after 3 weeks, or shows new signs (head tilt, circling, seizures, weakness).